Why the NFL Ended the Pro Bowl Games: A Viewership Analysis

Prepared November 2026 · Companion to the Pro Bowl viewership dashboard and dataset

Abstract

In 2026 the NFL discontinued its all-star game and the flag football and skills events that replaced it in 2023. This paper examines the public audience record from 2022 to 2026 and the reasons the league gave. Average viewership fell from 6.7 million (2022) to about 1.9 million (2026), a decline of roughly 70%. A simple linear trend fitted to 2022–2025 predicts about 4.25 million viewers for 2026, so roughly half of the total decline continued an existing trend and roughly half was an additional 2026 shock. Because the 2026 event changed day, network, venue and player pool at once, the shock cannot be attributed to any single factor.

1. Introduction

The Pro Bowl dates to 1951 and was a fixture of the NFL calendar for decades, including a long run in Honolulu from 1980 to 2009. Audiences peaked above 10 million per year from 2010 to 2014. The league rebranded the event as the Pro Bowl Games in 2023, built around flag football and skills challenges. In 2026 it moved the event to a Tuesday night in Super Bowl week at San Francisco's Moscone Center, and later announced it would stage no all-star event at all, naming 88 Pro Bowlers each year instead.

Research questions: (1) How did viewership change across formats? (2) How much of the 2026 audience can be explained by the prior trend? (3) Which explanations are best supported by the evidence?

2. Data and Method

The dataset contains five annual observations (2022–2026) of average television audience, compiled from trade-press reporting, along with format, day, network and venue. Figures are rounded and are not from a single measurement source.

An ordinary least squares line was fitted to 2022–2025 (n = 4) and extrapolated to 2026. The residual for 2026 is treated as the portion of the audience not explained by the prior trend. This is a descriptive device, not a causal estimate: with four points the fit has two degrees of freedom and no meaningful confidence interval.

3. Results

Year	Format	Viewers (M)	YoY
2022	Tackle game	6.7	n/a
2023	Flag + skills	6.3	-6%
2024	Flag + skills	5.8	-8%
2025	Flag + skills	4.7	-19%
2026	**Tuesday, indoors, ESPN**	**~1.9**	**-60%**

Table 1. Average Pro Bowl audience by year. YoY changes are computed from rounded figures.

The fitted line is Viewers = 6.85 - 0.65 x (years since 2022), with an R-squared of about 0.94 on the four fitting years. It predicts 4.25 million for 2026. The observed 1.92 million is about 2.3 million below the line (-55%). Of the 4.8 million total decline since 2022, about 2.45 million (51%) lies along the prior trend and about 2.3 million (49%) is the residual. As a second scenario, repeating the 2025 rate of decline (-19%) would have produced about 3.8 million.

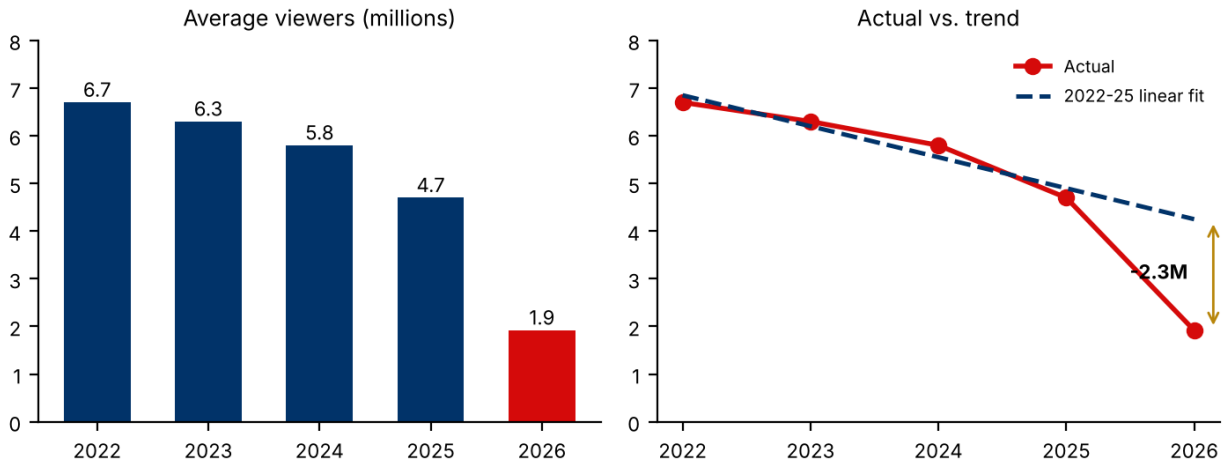


Figure 1. Left: average viewers by year (2026 in red). Right: actual audience against the 2022-2025 linear fit.

4. Discussion

Player participation. NFL executives said players told the league they did not want to compete after their season ended, and the physical nature of football makes a full-effort exhibition hard to justify. Reporting also noted record withdrawals in 2026. This is the best-supported explanation for the long-run trend.

Distribution and timing. The 2026 event left Sunday and broadcast television, ran on a weeknight, and was staged before an invited crowd of about 2,000. These changes coincide with the steepest drop, but they are confounded with one another.

League demand. NFL viewership was rising over the same period, which argues against a general decline in interest in the sport.

Comparison with other leagues. MLB, the NBA and the NHL have redesigned all-star formats to keep them competitive. The NFL's structure, with no midseason break and high injury risk, made those fixes harder, and the league chose to end the event.

5. Limitations

Five data points and rounded trade-press figures limit precision. Streaming and out-of-home viewing are not separately measured. The skills competition's audience was never reported on its own. The trend extrapolation assumes linearity, which the 2025 acceleration already questions.

6. Conclusion

The audience record shows a steady erosion that preceded the 2026 changes, followed by a sharp additional fall in the final year. The evidence supports a combined explanation: declining stakes and star participation

set the trend, and the 2026 scheduling and distribution changes likely deepened it. The league's own statement that player input and viewership both drove the decision is consistent with that picture.

References

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